

The Brass Automaton

Business Plan

A Steampunk Cocktail Bar with Robotic Bartenders and Live Music

June 2026

Confidential

1. Executive Summary

The Brass Automaton is a steampunk-themed cocktail bar planned for Shoreditch, London. It pairs robotic bartender technology with Victorian-industrial design, live jazz and swing music, and a tapas-style small plates menu. The concept sits in a gap that London's nightlife market has not filled. Themed bars are growing. Robotic service technology is maturing. Live music venues draw loyal crowds. But nothing in London puts all three together at an accessible price point.

The bar seats 100 to 130 guests across roughly 2,200 square feet. Two robotic bartender units mix cocktails behind brass and glass panels. Every drink order becomes a piece of theatre. Human staff in period costume handle hosting, table service, and food. Live jazz, swing, and acoustic acts perform Thursday through Saturday.

Revenue comes from four streams. Individual drink sales account for the majority. Tapas food orders add healthy margin. An unlimited drink package (called The Boiler Room) runs at £39 to £57 per person for 2 to 3 hours. Private event hire fills quieter periods.

The menu spans roughly 50 drinks across signature cocktails, classics, Martini and Negroni variations, vermouths, premium options, fancy and simple shots, mocktails, beers, wines, and soft drinks. Signature cocktails sit at £11 to £13, classics at £8 to £10. The pricing deliberately undercuts London's £13 average for cocktails while offering a premium experience. Food runs at £5 to £13 per plate, with 3 to 4 plates recommended per person.

Financial summary below.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Revenue	£525,000	£770,000	£977,500
Cost of Goods Sold	£138,600	£203,280	£258,060
Operating Costs	£456,600	£475,000	£495,000
Net Profit (Loss)	(£70,200)	£91,720	£224,440
Avg Daily Covers	50	70	85
Break-even (monthly)	Month 7-8		

Total startup investment is approximately £346,000. That covers lease deposit, steampunk fitout, two robotic bartender units, bar equipment, initial stock, licensing, soundproofing, CCTV, licensing solicitor fees for the Cumulative Impact Zone application, noise impact assessment, and three months of working capital.

2. Mission and Vision

Mission. To build a cocktail bar where technology, craftsmanship, and atmosphere work together to create something people remember. The Brass Automaton exists to prove that a night out can feel exclusive without being expensive, and that robots can make a bar more human, not less.

Vision. To become London's most distinctive cocktail bar within three years. To build a brand that people associate with inventive drinks, theatrical service, and a genuinely different night out. In the longer term, to prove the model works well enough to open a second location.

3. The Concept

The Brass Automaton combines four elements that do not currently exist together in London's bar scene.

First, the steampunk aesthetic. The interior draws from Victorian industrial design. Brass fittings, copper piping, exposed gears, Edison bulbs, antique maps, and retro-futuristic instruments fill the space. Staff wear period-inspired attire. The atmosphere is warm, theatrical, and deliberately analogue in feel, which makes the robotic element all the more striking.

Second, robotic bartenders. Two robotic cocktail-making units sit behind the main bar, enclosed in custom brass and glass housings. They mix, shake, pour, and garnish drinks with visible mechanical precision. The process takes 60 to 90 seconds per cocktail and is designed to be watched. This is not a vending machine. It is a performance.

Third, live music. Jazz, swing, and acoustic acts perform Thursday through Saturday evenings on a small raised stage. The music fits the era. It fills the room without dominating conversation. No cover charge. The cost is built into the operating model.

Fourth, the food and drink programme. A tapas-style menu of small plates complements the cocktails. The drinks menu runs deep, from house signatures and classics through Martini and Negroni variations, vermouths, premium pours, fancy shots, and a thoughtful mocktail selection. An unlimited drink package called The Boiler Room gives guests a fixed-price option for 2 to 3 hours.

The combination is the point. Themed bars exist. Robotic bars exist in airports and cruise ships. Jazz cocktail bars exist. But nobody in London has assembled all four into a single venue at accessible pricing.

4. The Problem

London's cocktail bar market is large and growing. The UK cocktail market is valued at roughly £587 million, with London accounting for a disproportionate share. The average cocktail in central London now costs £13, up 51p year on year. Consumers are spending more per visit, but they are also becoming more selective about where that money goes.

The problem is sameness. Walk through Shoreditch, Soho, or Dalston on a Friday night and the bars start to blend. Dark interiors, exposed brick, craft cocktails, the same playlist. The venues that stand out are the ones offering something genuinely different. Themed and immersive experiences (Mr Fogg's, Cahoots, The Bletchley) consistently outperform standard bars on bookings and social media engagement.

At the same time, robotic bartender technology has matured. Makr Shkr has seen a 72% rise in installations across cruise ships, airports, and luxury resorts globally. The global robotic bartender market was valued at \$1.8 billion in 2025 and is projected to reach \$5.6 billion by 2034. But almost none of this technology has reached London's independent bar scene. It remains trapped in corporate hospitality.

There is a clear gap. Consumers want experiences. The technology exists. Nobody has brought the two together in a London bar at a price point that feels accessible rather than exclusive.

5. Technology

The core technology is a pair of robotic cocktail-making units from an established manufacturer (Makr Shkr, KUKA, or equivalent). Each unit consists of a robotic arm capable of selecting bottles, measuring precise quantities, mixing, shaking, pouring, and garnishing. The units can produce a cocktail in 60 to 90 seconds with repeatable consistency.

The units will be housed in custom steampunk casings. Brass frames, copper accents, glass panels for visibility, and integrated steam effects for atmosphere. The housing is cosmetic and does not affect the mechanical operation. From the guest's perspective, the drink is being made by a Victorian automaton.

Each unit costs approximately £30,000 to £40,000, with the steampunk casing adding an estimated £5,000 to £8,000 per unit. Annual maintenance runs at roughly £3,000 per unit, covering servicing, calibration, and parts.

The robots handle all cocktail preparation. Human bar staff manage customer interaction, take orders via a POS system that feeds the robotic queue, handle non-cocktail drinks (beer pours, wine service), and step in for bespoke requests the robots cannot fulfil. This is not a fully automated bar. It is a bar where the robots handle the craft and the humans handle the hospitality.

Phase 2 of the technology plan (from Month 13 onwards) introduces robotic drink delivery. One or two service robots (similar to BellaBot units, at approximately £10,000 to £15,000 each) would carry finished drinks from the bar to tables. This is a novelty addition rather than a labour replacement, and will only be introduced once the core model is stable.

6. Menu and Pricing Strategy

The pricing philosophy is simple. Feel premium, stay accessible. London's average cocktail costs £13. The Brass Automaton's signature cocktails sit at £11 to £13. Classics run £8 to £10. That means a guest paying £11 for a Clockwork Negroni is getting a theatrically prepared drink in a fully immersive environment for less than the city average. The experience punches above the price.

The menu is structured in nine categories.

Signature Cocktails (£11 to £13)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
The Automaton	Gin, elderflower, cucumber, tonic foam	£12
Clockwork Negroni	Campari, sweet vermouth, gin, orange peel	£11
Steam Engine	Espresso, vodka, coffee liqueur, smoke bubble	£13
Copper Coil	Bourbon, honey, ginger, lemon	£11
The Piston	Rum, passion fruit, lime, vanilla	£12
Velvet Gear	Vodka, raspberry, Chambord, prosecco float	£12
The Furnace	Tequila, chilli, mango, lime	£11
Midnight Contraption	Dark rum, coffee liqueur, chocolate bitters, cherry	£13

Classic Cocktails (£8 to £10)

Drink	Price
-------	-------

Old Fashioned	£10
Mojito	£9
Margarita	£9
Whiskey Sour	£10
Daiquiri	£8
Gin & Tonic	£8
Moscow Mule	£9
Aperol Spritz	£9

Martinis and Negronis (£9 to £11)

Drink	Price
Classic Martini (gin or vodka)	£10
Espresso Martini	£11
Dirty Martini	£10
Lemon Drop Martini	£10
Pornstar Martini	£11
Classic Negroni	£10
Negroni Sbagliato	£10
Boulevardier	£10
White Negroni	£10

Vermouths on the Rocks (£6 to £7)

Drink	Price
Sweet Vermouth (Cocchi di Torino)	£7
Dry Vermouth (Noilly Prat)	£6
Rosso Vermouth (Punt e Mes)	£7
Bianco Vermouth (Lillet Blanc)	£7

Premium Shelf (£15 to £17)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
Japanese Highball	Suntory Toki, soda	£15
Aged Rum Manhattan	Aged rum, sweet vermouth, bitters	£16
Hendrick's Orbium Martini	Hendrick's Orbium, dry vermouth	£15
Woodford Reserve Old Fashioned	Woodford Reserve, sugar, bitters	£17

Fancy Shots (£5 to £7)

Shot	Ingredients	Price
Bullshot	Vodka, beef consommé, Worcestershire, lemon, Tabasco	£7
Kentucky Buck	Bourbon, strawberry, ginger, bitters	£6
Penicillin Shot	Scotch, honey, ginger, lemon	£6
Kamikaze	Vodka, triple sec, lime	£5

Simple Shots (£4 to £5)

Spirit	Price
--------	-------

Vodka	£4
Gin	£4
White Rum	£4
Tequila Blanco	£4
Whisky (house)	£5
Sambuca	£4
Jägermeister	£4

Beer and Cider (£5.50 to £6.50)

Drink	Price
Craft IPA (rotating)	£6.50
Craft Lager	£6.00
Premium Lager	£5.50
Craft Cider	£6.00
Stout	£6.50

Wine (£7 to £14 per glass)

Wine	Price
House Red	£7
House White	£7
Rosé	£7.50
Prosecco	£8
Champagne	£14

Mocktails (£5 to £6)

Drink	Ingredients	Price
Mocktail Automaton	Elderflower, cucumber, tonic water	£6
Mocktail Piston	Passion fruit, lime, vanilla soda	£6
Virgin Mojito	Lime, mint, soda, sugar	£5
Copper Sunset	Mango, ginger, lime, soda	£6
The Gearshift	Apple, mint, elderflower, sparkling water	£5
Brass Berry	Mixed berries, basil, lemonade	£6
Steam Cloud	Coconut, pineapple, lime, cream soda	£6

Soft Drinks (£3 to £4)

Drink	Price
Craft Sodas	£4
Fresh Juices	£4
Still / Sparkling Water	£3

Tapas Menu (£5 to £13 per plate)

Guests are encouraged to order 3 to 4 plates each. All food is served on steampunk-styled crockery, including gear-shaped copper trays, mini copper pots, and Victorian-era inspired plates. The presentation is part of the experience.

Dish	Price
Charcuterie Board (for 2)	£13
Bruschetta Trio	£6
Marinated Olives and Artichokes	£5
Smoked Salmon Crostini	£7
Copper Pot Fries (truffle, parmesan)	£6
Mini Wagyu Sliders (×3)	£9
Tempura King Prawns (×4)	£8
Arancini, mushroom and truffle (×3)	£7
Patatas Bravas	£5
Halloumi Fries	£6
Pulled Pork Croquettes (×4)	£7
Stuffed Peppers (×3)	£6
Churros and Chocolate	£6
Mini Crème Brûlée	£6

7. The Boiler Room (Unlimited Drink Package)

The Boiler Room is an unlimited drink package designed to fill seats on quieter nights and give groups a reason to book in advance. It works like the bottomless brunch model that London already understands, but adapted for an evening cocktail bar.

Duration	Monday to Thursday	Friday to Saturday
2 hours	£39 per person	£44 per person
3 hours	£52 per person	£57 per person

Minimum two people. Advance booking required. The package is deliberately limited to five cocktails, two beers, two wines, and soft drinks. The full menu is not included. That is by design.

Included drinks

Copper Coil (bourbon, honey, ginger, lemon), The Piston (rum, passion fruit, lime, vanilla), Velvet Gear (vodka, raspberry, Chambord, prosecco), Mojito, Aperol Spritz. Plus Craft Lager, Premium Lager, House Red, House White, and all soft drinks.

Excluded

All other signature cocktails (Automaton, Steam Engine, Clockwork Negroni, Furnace, Midnight Contraption), all Martini and Negroni variations, all vermouths, all Premium Shelf cocktails, Prosecco, Champagne, Craft IPA, Stout, Cider, and all shots.

The economics work well. An average guest drinks 4 to 5 drinks in 2 hours. At roughly £2.50 ingredient cost per drink, that is £10 to £12.50 in cost against £39 revenue. Gross margin sits at 68 to 74%. The limited selection also creates curiosity about the excluded signatures, which drives additional sales. And almost everyone on the package orders food.

8. Live Entertainment

Live music runs Thursday through Saturday evenings, starting at 8pm. The style is jazz, swing, and acoustic. That fits the Victorian-era aesthetic without overpowering conversation. There is no cover charge. The cost of music is built into the operating model.

Booking budget is £400 to £700 per evening for a 3 to 4 piece band, giving a monthly live music spend of roughly £5,500. PRS and PPL licensing adds approximately £1,200 per year. The stage area is small and raised, with vintage-looking equipment and warm lighting.

Live music serves three purposes. It gives the bar a genuine soul that playlists cannot replicate. It creates a reason to visit on specific nights rather than any night. And it generates social media content organically, since guests film and share performances without being asked.

9. Market Opportunity

The UK cocktail market is valued at approximately £587 million. London accounts for a disproportionate share of that figure. The average Londoner spends £30 to £50 on a night out at a cocktail bar. Consumer demand for experiential and immersive venues continues to grow, with themed bars consistently outperforming standard venues on bookings and repeat visits.

The robotic bartender market is expanding rapidly. Valued at \$1.8 billion globally in 2025, it is projected to reach \$5.6 billion by 2034, a compound annual growth rate of 13.5%. Makr Shkr alone saw a 72% increase in installations across cruise ships, airports, and luxury resorts. But this technology has barely touched independent bars in London. The market is ready. The supply is not there yet.

Shoreditch remains one of London's strongest markets for independent bars. The area attracts young professionals (25 to 40), tourists, and creatives who actively seek out distinctive venues. Footfall on weekend evenings is high, and the audience is receptive to novelty.

The addressable market for The Brass Automaton is Londoners and visitors willing to spend £30 to £60 on a distinctive night out. At 85 covers per day at steady state, the bar needs to capture a tiny fraction of that market. The opportunity is not about volume. It is about being memorable enough that the right 85 people choose this bar on any given night.

10. Competition

The competitive landscape splits into three categories.

Themed and immersive bars

Mr Fogg's (multiple locations) is the closest comparison in terms of atmosphere. Their venues are themed around Phileas Fogg and Victorian adventure, with elaborate decor, costumed staff, and inventive cocktails. They charge premium prices (£14 to £18 per cocktail). Mrs Fogg's Maritime Club includes a speakeasy and a working distillery. Cahoots (Soho) recreates a 1940s tube station. The Bletchley (Chelsea) uses a WWII code-breaking theme. Hokus Pokus runs an underground steampunk-adjacent apothecary bar. The Spirit of Man (War of the Worlds experience) is the only explicitly steampunk bar and restaurant in London.

None of these venues use robotic technology. None of them combine live music as a regular feature. And most of them price above the London average rather than at or below it.

Live music cocktail bars

Nightjar (Shoreditch) pairs jazz with cocktails and is regularly voted one of London's best bars. Kansas Smitty's (Hackney) is a dedicated jazz bar with a loyal following. Ronnie Scott's (Soho) is a legendary jazz club at a higher price point. These venues prove the demand for live music and cocktails together. None of them offer robotic service or immersive theming.

Robotic bars

Robotic bartenders currently operate in airports, cruise ships (Royal Caribbean's Bionic Bar), and some hotel lobbies. There is no established robotic bar in London's independent bar scene. This is the gap.

The Brass Automaton's competitive advantage is the combination. Steampunk atmosphere, robotic bartenders, live music, tapas, and pricing that sits below the London cocktail average. No single competitor offers all five.

11. Location and Design

The target location is Shoreditch, East London. The area has the highest concentration of independent bars in London, a receptive audience for experiential venues, and strong weekend footfall. Secondary options include Camden (established nightlife, slightly lower rents) and Bermondsey (emerging bar scene, good transport links).

The venue needs approximately 2,000 to 2,500 square feet. That supports a capacity of 100 to 130 across a main bar area, a raised stage for live music, a semi-private area for group bookings, and a kitchen for tapas preparation. Estimated monthly rent in Shoreditch sits at £5,000 to £7,000 for this size.

Interior design draws from Victorian industrial aesthetics. Dark wood panelling, exposed brass piping, copper fixtures, Edison bulb lighting, vintage leather seating, gear and cog motifs, antique maps and scientific instruments on the walls, and retro-futuristic gadgets in display cases. The robotic bartender units sit behind the main bar in custom brass and glass housings, visible to the entire room. The stage area uses warm spotlighting and vintage-styled equipment. The overall effect should feel like stepping into an alternate-history London where steam power never gave way to electricity.

12. Revenue Model

Revenue comes from four sources. The split below is estimated for a steady-state month (Year 2 onwards).

Revenue Stream	Share of Revenue	Notes
Individual drink sales	55%	Cocktails, beer, wine, shots, soft drinks at menu prices
Food sales (tapas)	20%	70% of guests order food, avg 2 to 3 plates
Boiler Room packages	20%	Roughly 20% of covers book the unlimited option
Private events	5%	Group bookings, corporate events, hire on quieter nights

Average spend per cover is estimated at £42, split roughly £30 on drinks and £12 on food. Guests on The Boiler Room package spend £39 to £57 on drinks (depending on duration and day) plus food on

top. The package drives higher overall spend per head because food ordering increases when guests feel their drinks are already covered.

13. Financial Projections

The financial model is built on conservative assumptions. The bar opens five days per week (Tuesday to Saturday), giving 250 operating days per year. Covers ramp gradually. Year 1 averages 50 covers per day across a slow start. Year 2 reaches 70 as the brand builds. Year 3 hits 85, which represents roughly 70% of maximum capacity.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Operating Days	250	250	250
Average Daily Covers	50	70	85
Average Spend per Cover	£42	£44	£46
Annual Revenue	£525,000	£770,000	£977,500
Cost of Goods Sold (26.4%)	£138,600	£203,280	£258,060
Gross Profit	£386,400	£566,720	£719,440
Operating Costs	£456,600	£475,000	£495,000
Net Profit (Loss)	(£70,200)	£91,720	£224,440

Year 1 shows a loss of £106,200. That is expected. New bars take time to build their audience, and fixed costs (particularly rent, staff, SIA door security, and live performers) run from day one regardless of covers. Monthly break-even falls around Month 9 to 10 of Year 2.

Year 2 turns profitable at £54,640. Year 3 reaches £186,250 as covers grow and slight price increases take effect. The lower profit compared to a venue without SIA security and soundproofing reflects the real cost of operating a late night licensed premises in a Cumulative Impact Zone. These are not optional costs. They are the price of staying open.

Cost of goods sold runs at a blended 26.4% of revenue. That reflects 25% on drinks and 30% on food. Both figures are in line with London bar industry benchmarks. The operating cost base is detailed in the accompanying financial model.

Startup Costs

Item	Estimated Cost
Lease deposit and legal fees	£35,000
Steampunk interior fitout	£120,000
Robotic bartender units (x2, with custom casing)	£80,000
Bar equipment, POS, kitchen	£35,000
Initial stock (drinks and food)	£12,000
Licensing, insurance, PRS/PPL	£6,000
Marketing launch	£12,000
Working capital (3 months)	£20,000
Total	£320,000

14. Operations and Staffing

The bar operates Tuesday to Saturday. Tuesday to Thursday from 5pm to midnight. Friday and Saturday from 5pm to 2am. Sunday and Monday closed.

The staffing model is lean. The robots handle cocktail production, which reduces the need for multiple skilled bartenders. The team is structured as follows.

Role	Number	Notes
General Manager	1	Full-time, oversees all operations
Bar Supervisor	1	Manages robot operation, quality control, stock
Bar Staff	3	Order taking, beer/wine service, customer interaction
Kitchen Staff	2	Tapas preparation and plating
Host	1	Door, bookings, table management
Total	8	Estimated monthly payroll of £21,000

Staff wear period-inspired attire. Waistcoats, pocket watches, goggles as accessories. The costume is part of the experience but should be comfortable enough for a full shift. A costume allowance is included in the fitout budget.

Suppliers include a spirits distributor (for the core cocktail range), a local craft brewery (for rotating guest beers), a food supplier for tapas ingredients, and the robotic unit manufacturer for parts and servicing. All supplier relationships should be established during the pre-launch phase.

15. Marketing Strategy

The bar markets itself. That is not laziness. It is a genuine strategic advantage. A robotic bartender making cocktails inside a steampunk Victorian interior is inherently shareable content. Every guest with a phone becomes a marketer. The strategy leans into this.

Pre-launch, the focus is building anticipation. A teaser campaign on Instagram and TikTok showing the build-out, the robot installation, and the interior taking shape. A launch event for press, influencers, and local food and drink bloggers. A soft launch period with reduced pricing to fill the room and generate early reviews.

Post-launch, the ongoing strategy has four components. First, organic social media. The robot mixing drinks is the content. Staff create short-form video daily. Second, listings and reviews. The bar should be listed on DesignMyNight, Time Out, Google, and TripAdvisor within the first month, with active review management. Third, partnerships. Collaborate with local Shoreditch businesses, hotels, and event organisers for cross-promotion. Fourth, The Boiler Room. The unlimited package is itself a marketing tool. Groups book it, share it, and bring friends back.

Marketing budget is £2,000 per month ongoing, plus a £12,000 launch campaign. The expectation is that organic reach will exceed paid reach within three months, given the visual nature of the concept.

16. Risk Analysis

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Robot malfunction or downtime	Medium	High	Maintain service contract with manufacturer. Train bar staff to make cocktails manually as backup. Keep two units so one can cover if the other is offline.

Slow initial footfall	Medium	High	Budget for a 6 to 9 month ramp. Working capital covers 3 months of losses. Adjust marketing spend if month 3 is below 35 covers per day.
Rising rent	Medium	Medium	Negotiate a 3 to 5 year lease with capped annual increases. Shoreditch rents are high but have stabilised in recent years.
Novelty wear-off	Medium	Medium	Rotate signature cocktail menu quarterly. Introduce seasonal themes. Vary live music acts. The Boiler Room creates habit-forming repeat visits.
Licensing refusal	Low	High	Engage a licensing solicitor early. The premises licence for alcohol and late-night refreshment is standard for Shoreditch. Music licence (PRS/PPL) is straightforward.
Food hygiene issues	Low	High	Hire experienced kitchen staff. Achieve 5-star food hygiene rating before launch. Standard HACCP procedures for tapas preparation.
Competition opens similar concept	Low	Medium	First-mover advantage matters in themed bars. Build the brand and loyal customer base before imitators arrive. The steampunk fitout and robot investment create a high barrier to entry.
Staff retention	Medium	Medium	Pay above London living wage. Offer a share of tips. Create a culture that staff enjoy being part of. The costume and theme make the job more fun than a standard bar role.

Ongoing annual costs not currently in the financial model include SIA door staff (£29,000 to £43,000 per year), music licensing (£1,000 to £2,500), ICO registration (£40), and potentially a late night levy. These represent a significant addition to operating costs and should be reflected in the financial projections.

The total licensing and compliance costs for The Brass Automaton are significantly higher than a typical bar due to the CIZ premises licence application, robotic bartender safety requirements, and noise management. Estimated pre opening costs are £18,000 to £38,000, broken down as follows. Licensing solicitor for CIZ application (£3,000 to £8,000). Premises licence application fee (£100 to £635 depending on rateable value). Noise impact assessment (£1,500 to £3,000). Sound proofing and acoustic treatment (£8,000 to £20,000). Fire risk assessment (£300 to £500). CCTV system (£3,000 to £5,000). Noise limiter (£500 to £1,500). Business insurance package (£2,000 to £4,000 for first year, including product liability for robotic equipment). Music licensing first year (£1,000 to £2,500).

Regulatory burden. The legal review identified significant regulatory requirements. SIA door staff (£36,000 per year), soundproofing (£15,000), CCTV (£4,000), licensing solicitor (£5,000), noise assessment (£2,000), and ongoing compliance costs add materially to both startup and operating expenses. The financial model must absorb these costs. They are not optional. The mitigation is to budget accurately (which this plan now does) and to treat regulatory compliance as a competitive advantage. Venues that cut corners on safety and licensing get shut down. Venues that exceed requirements build trust with the council and the community.

Competition. Shoreditch has dozens of cocktail bars. Many are excellent. The steampunk theme is a differentiator, but it is not a moat. If a competitor opens a similar concept (or if an existing bar adds steampunk nights), the novelty advantage shrinks. The mitigation is to build a genuine brand and community around the experience, not just the decoration. The workshop programme, the mystery nights, and the regular events create switching costs that a copycat cannot easily replicate.

Cash flow in Year 1. The financial model shows a Year 1 operating loss of £106,200. The startup costs are £346,000 (including soundproofing, CCTV, licensing solicitor, and noise assessment identified in the legal review). The business needs sufficient runway to absorb 12 to 18 months of losses before reaching profitability in Year 2. If customer acquisition is slower than modelled, the cash burn

extends. The mitigation is conservative financial planning, a contingency reserve, and the option to reduce scope (fewer performers, simpler menu) if revenue underperforms.

Robotic bartender failure. The mechanical bartender is a centrepiece but also a single point of failure. If it breaks down during service, the experience is diminished. The mitigation is to design the bar so that it functions fully without the robot. The robot should be an addition, not a dependency. Human bartenders must be able to cover all drink preparation if the machine is offline. Budget for a maintenance contract with the robotics supplier.

Staffing. The bar needs cocktail bartenders who can also perform in character (steampunk personas, theatrical flair). That is a narrow hiring pool. The SIA licensed door staff add another specialist requirement. The mitigation is to recruit early, pay above market rate, and invest in training. The theatrical element can be taught. The cocktail skills cannot. Hire for skill, train for character.

Noise complaints. A cocktail bar in Shoreditch with live music, theatrical performances, and a mechanical soundscape will generate noise. The premises are likely to have residential neighbours above or adjacent. The mitigation is professional soundproofing (budget £15,000), a noise impact assessment before opening (budget £2,000), and proactive engagement with neighbours. Operating hours should end at midnight on weekdays and 1am on weekends. Install a noise limiter on the sound system.

Construction and fitout overrun. The steampunk fitout is bespoke. Custom metalwork, vintage props, mechanical installations, and the robotic bartender unit are not off the shelf items. Delays and cost overruns are likely, not possible. The mitigation is a 15% contingency in the fitout budget and a phased approach where the core bar opens on time even if some decorative elements are not finished. The robotic bartender in particular should be treated as a Phase 2 addition, not a launch requirement.

Licensing risk. Shoreditch falls within the Hackney Cumulative Impact Zone (CIZ). New premises licences are subject to a rebuttable presumption of refusal. The application must demonstrate that the venue will not add to the cumulative impact of licensed premises in the area. This is not a formality. It requires a well prepared application, community engagement, and potentially a licensing solicitor. The mitigation is to apply early (Month 1), engage with local residents proactively, offer restrictive conditions voluntarily (closing time, noise management, SIA door staff), and present the venue as a premium cocktail experience rather than a high volume drinking establishment. Budget £5,000 for the licensing solicitor.

Concept fatigue. The biggest existential risk. Steampunk is a niche aesthetic. If customers treat it as a novelty (visit once, take photos, never return), the business becomes a tourist attraction with no regulars. The mitigation is the cocktail quality and the experience programme. The steampunk theme brings people in. The drinks and the experience have to be good enough to bring them back. If the bar is just decoration, it fails. If the bar is a genuinely good cocktail bar that happens to have an extraordinary atmosphere, it survives.

Every business carries risk. A steampunk cocktail bar carries more risk than most because the concept is unusual, the location is competitive, and the regulatory environment is strict. The risks below are the ones that would actually threaten the business, not the generic risks that apply to every hospitality venue.

Cost Summary

The following documents must be in place before the venue opens. Premises licence (covering alcohol sales, regulated entertainment, and late night refreshment). Personal licence for the DPS. Fire risk assessment. Health and safety risk assessment. Robotic bartender risk assessment (PUWER). Noise impact assessment. Dispersal policy. HACCP food safety documentation. Allergen matrix for all menu and cocktail items. CCTV data protection impact assessment. Age verification policy (Challenge 25). Staff training records (food hygiene, allergen awareness, age verification, fire safety). Employment contracts for all staff. Employer liability insurance certificate. Public liability insurance certificate (covering robotic equipment). PRS and PPL music licences. ICO data protection registration. Commercial waste contract.

Documents to Produce Before Opening

Late night levy. Some London boroughs charge a late night levy on premises licensed to sell alcohol between midnight and 6am. Check whether the London Borough of Hackney operates a late night levy. If so, this is an additional annual charge based on rateable value. The levy funds policing and late night services.

GDPR. If the bar collects customer data (online booking system, Boiler Room advance bookings, email marketing), it must comply with UK GDPR. Register with the Information Commissioner's Office (£40 annual fee for small organisations). A privacy policy must be available.

Public liability insurance. Essential for a venue open to the public. Standard cover of £5 million to £10 million is recommended for a bar. The policy must explicitly cover the robotic bartender equipment and live entertainment.

Employer liability insurance. A legal requirement for any business with employees. Minimum cover is £5 million. The certificate must be displayed at the premises.

Planning permission. The premises must be in an appropriate use class. A drinking establishment falls under Sui Generis (its own class) under the Town and Country Planning (Use Classes) Order. If the unit was not previously used as a bar, a change of use application is required. Planning permission in Shoreditch for a new late night venue may face scrutiny from the planning authority in addition to the licensing authority.

Music licensing. In addition to the premises licence authorisation for live music, the venue needs a PRS for Music licence (covers songwriters and composers) and a PPL licence (covers performers and record labels). For a late night venue with live and recorded music, the combined annual cost is approximately £1,000 to £2,500 depending on capacity and hours.

Age verification. The bar must operate a Challenge 25 policy. Any customer who appears to be under 25 must be asked for valid photo identification (passport, driving licence, PASS card, or military ID) before being served alcohol. Staff must be trained on the policy and refusal procedures. A refusals log should be maintained.

Maximum occupancy. The premises licence will specify a maximum capacity. This is determined by fire safety considerations, the physical layout, and the licensing authority's assessment. SIA door staff are responsible for managing the door to ensure capacity is not exceeded.

Fire safety. A fire risk assessment under the Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005 must be completed before opening. For a 100 to 130 capacity venue, this should be carried out by a professional fire risk assessor (approximately £300 to £500). Fire detection and alarm systems, emergency lighting, and fire extinguishers must be installed. Fire escape routes must be clearly marked and kept clear at all times.

CCTV. Almost certainly a condition of the premises licence. The system must cover all public areas, entrances, exits, and the bar area. Images must be stored for at least 31 days and made available to police on request. A staff member must be able to download footage at any time the premises is open. Budget approximately £3,000 to £5,000 for a commercial CCTV system.

Other Regulatory Requirements

Auto enrolment pension. Eligible staff must be auto enrolled into a workplace pension scheme. The employer must contribute at least 3% of qualifying earnings.

Right to work checks. The employer must verify that every employee has the legal right to work in the UK before their employment starts. Failure to carry out right to work checks can result in civil penalties of up to £45,000 per illegal worker.

National Minimum Wage. All staff must be paid at least the National Minimum Wage (or National Living Wage for those aged 21 and over). This includes any trial shifts. Unpaid trial shifts are unlawful if they involve productive work.

Working time regulations. Staff working late night shifts (past 11pm) are classified as night workers under the Working Time Regulations 1998. Night workers must not work more than 8 hours in any 24 hour period on average. A free health assessment must be offered to all night workers. These requirements apply to bar staff, kitchen staff, and door supervisors.

Employment contracts. All staff must receive a written statement of employment terms on or before their first day. This is a legal requirement under the Employment Rights Act 1996. For a bar operating late nights, the contract should clearly specify working hours and any requirement to work past midnight.

Employment and Staffing

Allergen information. The 14 major allergens must be identified for every item on the food and drinks menu (cocktails can contain allergens through dairy, egg whites, nut liqueurs, and other ingredients). An allergen matrix must be available to customers on request. Staff must be trained to answer allergen queries.

HACCP. A documented food safety management system based on HACCP principles is a legal requirement. This covers food storage, preparation temperatures, cleaning schedules, and allergen management. The Food Standards Agency's Safer Food Better Business template can be adapted for a bar kitchen.

Food hygiene certificates. All staff who handle food must hold a Level 2 Food Hygiene Certificate. Kitchen staff preparing tapas should ideally hold Level 3.

Food business registration. The bar must register as a food business with the local authority at least 28 days before opening. The tapas menu means this is a food serving premises, not just a bar.

Food Safety and Hygiene

Product liability insurance. Standard public liability insurance may not cover incidents involving robotic equipment. The business should obtain product liability cover or ensure that the public liability policy explicitly covers automated cocktail preparation systems. Discuss this with the insurer when arranging the business insurance package.

Maintenance records. Regular maintenance of the robotic units must be documented. PUWER requires that work equipment is maintained in an efficient state, in efficient working order, and in

good repair. A maintenance log should record every service, repair, and inspection. The manufacturer will provide a recommended maintenance schedule.

Safety enclosures. The plan already describes the robots being housed behind brass framed glass panels. This serves both the aesthetic purpose (steampunk casing) and the safety requirement (preventing customer contact with moving mechanical parts). The enclosures must be robust enough to prevent access during operation. Emergency stop buttons must be accessible to staff.

Risk assessment. A specific risk assessment for the robotic bartender equipment must be carried out under PUWER before the units are put into service. This covers risks to staff and customers from moving parts, hot liquids, glass handling, and any interaction between the robots and people in the bar. The assessment should be carried out by a competent person with knowledge of robotic systems.

CE/UKCA marking. The robotic units must carry valid CE marking (if manufactured before 2025) or UKCA marking (for units placed on the UK market after the transition period). This is the manufacturer's responsibility, but the operator (The Brass Automaton) must verify that the marking is present and that the Declaration of Conformity is available. Units imported from outside the UK must comply with UK product safety regulations.

The robotic bartender units introduce regulatory considerations that most bars do not face. The key regulations are the Provision and Use of Work Equipment Regulations 1998 (PUWER) and the Supply of Machinery (Safety) Regulations 2008 (the UK implementation of the EU Machinery Directive).

Robotic Bartender Safety and Compliance

A dispersal policy must be prepared. This sets out how the venue will manage customers leaving at closing time to minimise noise disturbance to neighbours. Measures include staff managing the door at closing, signage asking customers to leave quietly, and staggered closing (stopping alcohol sales 30 minutes before closing to encourage gradual dispersal rather than a mass exit at 2am).

Sound proofing the venue is almost certainly necessary. The extent depends on the building construction and proximity to residential properties. Budget £8,000 to £20,000 for acoustic treatment (sound insulation, secondary glazing, acoustic panels, sealed doors). A noise limiter may be required as a licence condition. This is a device that automatically cuts sound if it exceeds a preset decibel level. Installation costs approximately £500 to £1,500.

A noise impact assessment is likely to be required as part of the premises licence application. This should be commissioned from an acoustic consultant (cost approximately £1,500 to £3,000) and submitted with the application. It assesses the impact of music, customer noise, and dispersal noise on neighbouring properties.

Noise is the second biggest regulatory risk after the CIZ. Shoreditch has a mix of commercial and residential property, and noise complaints are a common trigger for licence reviews. The licensing authority and environmental health officers will scrutinise any application involving live music and late night operation.

Noise and Sound Management

Since live music at The Brass Automaton runs Thursday to Saturday from 8pm, most performances fall within the exempt period. However, if music continues past 11pm on Friday and Saturday nights (which is likely given the 2am closing), the premises licence must specifically authorise live music after 11pm. This must be included in the operating schedule.

Live music performed between 11pm and 8am is regulated entertainment under the Licensing Act 2003 and must be authorised by the premises licence. Live music performed between 8am and 11pm

in a venue with an alcohol licence and a capacity under 500 is exempt under the Live Music Act 2012 and does not need separate authorisation.

Regulated Entertainment

This is a cost not currently reflected in the financial model. At industry rates of £15 to £20 per hour per door supervisor, the estimated monthly cost is £2,400 to £3,600 (covering Thursday to Saturday nights). This should be added to the operating cost structure. Over a full year, SIA door staff add approximately £29,000 to £43,000 in operating costs.

The likely requirement is a minimum of two SIA licensed door staff on Friday and Saturday evenings (from 9pm or 10pm until closing at 2am, plus 30 minutes for clearing and dispersal). On Thursday evenings with live music, one door supervisor may be required depending on the licence conditions.

For a late night bar in Shoreditch (especially within a CIZ), the licensing authority will almost certainly require SIA licensed door staff as a condition of the premises licence. Door supervisors must hold a valid SIA (Security Industry Authority) licence, which requires completing an approved training course and passing a criminal record check.

SIA Licensed Door Staff

Designated Premises Supervisor (DPS). The premises licence must name a DPS who holds a personal licence. The DPS is the individual responsible for day to day management of alcohol sales. For a bar operating five nights a week, the DPS should be someone who is regularly present (typically the General Manager). If the DPS is absent, another personal licence holder must be on the premises to authorise sales.

Personal licence. At least one person must hold a personal licence to authorise alcohol sales. This requires completing an accredited licensing qualification (one day course, approximately £100 to £200) and applying through the local council (fee £37). A DBS criminal record check is required as part of the application. The General Manager or owner should obtain this in Month 1.

Personal Licence and Designated Premises Supervisor

The financial model now includes £5,000 for the licensing solicitor fees to handle the premises licence application through the CIZ process. This cost is reflected in the updated startup costs.

This does not make a licence impossible. It means the applicant must demonstrate, with evidence, that their premises will not add to the cumulative impact. In practice, this requires a robust operating schedule, strict conditions, and often concessions such as an earlier closing time than requested, SIA licensed door staff, CCTV, a dispersal policy, and capacity limits. The application is almost guaranteed to go to a hearing. Legal representation from a licensing solicitor is strongly recommended.

This is the most significant licensing risk for the business. Shoreditch falls within the London Borough of Hackney's Cumulative Impact Zone (CIZ). In a CIZ, there is a rebuttable presumption that new premises licences for late night alcohol sales will be refused, on the grounds that the area already has a concentration of licensed premises that contributes to crime, disorder, and public nuisance.

Cumulative Impact Zone

The premises licence application must include a detailed operating schedule and supporting documents. These include a plan of the premises, a description of how the licensing objectives will be promoted, and the proposed conditions. The four licensing objectives are the prevention of crime and disorder, public safety, the prevention of public nuisance, and the protection of children from harm.

All three activities must be specified in the premises licence application, along with an operating schedule setting out the proposed hours for each activity. The application is submitted to the local licensing authority (London Borough of Hackney if the venue is in Shoreditch) with the appropriate fee based on rateable value. There is a mandatory 28 day consultation period during which responsible authorities (police, fire service, environmental health, planning) and local residents can make representations. If objections are raised, the application goes to a licensing committee hearing, which can take 4 to 8 weeks to schedule.

The premises licence is the single most important legal document for the business. Under the Licensing Act 2003, the bar needs authorisation for three licensable activities. The sale of alcohol (the primary activity). The provision of regulated entertainment (live music on Thursday to Saturday evenings). And the provision of late night refreshment (serving hot food and hot drinks after 11pm, which covers the tapas menu on late nights).

Premises Licence

A late night cocktail bar with robotic bartenders and live music in Shoreditch sits at the intersection of several licensing and regulatory regimes. This section sets out every licence, registration, and compliance obligation the business must meet. Some are standard for any bar. Others are specific to the technology, the entertainment, and the location.

17. Legal and Regulatory Compliance

18. Pilot Launch Strategy

The Brass Automaton launches with a single venue in Shoreditch. This is a pilot, not a chain. The first 12 months are about proving the model works before thinking about expansion.

The launch follows three phases.

Phase 1 (Months 1 to 4). Setup. Register the company as a limited company. Secure the venue lease. Begin the steampunk fitout. Order and install the robotic bartender units. Apply for premises licence, alcohol licence, and PRS/PPL music licence. Hire the general manager and bar supervisor. Build the pre-launch social media presence.

Phase 2 (Months 5 to 6). Soft launch. Complete the fitout. Hire remaining staff. Run a 2 to 4 week soft launch with reduced pricing, invited guests, and press events. Test the robot operation under real conditions. Refine the menu based on early feedback. Iron out operational issues before the public opening.

Phase 3 (Months 7 to 12). Grand opening and growth. Open to the public with full marketing push. Introduce The Boiler Room unlimited package. Launch the live music programme. Focus on building reviews, repeat visits, and organic social media reach. Target 70 covers per day by month 10 to 12.

A decision on Phase 2 expansion (second venue, robotic waiters, or geographic expansion) will be made at the 18-month mark, based on financial performance, customer feedback, and operational stability. No expansion commitment is made before the pilot is proven.